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6 years after COVID's hardest hit, a fresh start

New veterans home reflects lessons learned

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

HOLYOKE — Six years after COVID claimed the lives of at least 76 elderly veterans at the former Soldiers' Home here, the searing memory of that tragedy — and the scandalous incompetence that enabled it — continue to gnaw at the families who lost loved ones.

Some never returned to the 74-year-old building near the Connecticut River. Others are still angry at the startling scale of neglect and mismanagement that fueled what is believed to be the nation's deadliest COVID outbreak at a long-term-care facility.

But now, a new building has arisen beside the scene of so much sorrow. Rebranded as the Veterans Home at Holyoke, the curved, state-of-the-art, eight-story structure atop Cherry Hill is "like a phoenix rising from the ashes," said John Paradis, a former Soldiers' Home deputy superintendent who resigned a decade

HOLYOKE, Page A10

Still unclear what question on primaries would mean

Western states haven't seen dramatic changes

By Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Would a radical change to local elections inject more competition and excitement to politics in Massachusetts, or just turn out to be another way to stymie independent candidates and newcomers?

That's the challenge posed by Question 3, the ballot referendum from a coalition of advocates and elected officials, backed by millions of dollars in private equity cash, that would eliminate the current party-based primary elections in favor of a nonpartisan preliminary open to candidates of all stripes.

Backers say Question 3 would make the state's elections more competitive, even boost turnout. But, the opponents retort, so could the chances of wealthy candidates dominating.

Answers to whether those possibilities have merit may lie to the West.

Question 3 on Tuesday's ballot would replace the state's current primary elections that Democratic, Republican, and third-party candidates run on separate ballots with one in which all candidates appear on a single ballot. Voters would select their favorite, and the top two —

QUESTION, Page A7

Some stability on natural gas bills

Winter rates will hold steady for most, and small credits coming

By Karyna Cheung
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Most natural gas customers in Massachusetts are set for a mild reprieve amid a year of punishing increases in household expenses, as state regulators on Friday signed off plans that will hold bills mostly steady for hundreds of thousands of homes and businesses this winter.

The state's Department of Public Utilities approved winter rates that will keep costs virtually the same for National Grid customers as last year, while Eversource customers will see a more mixed bill: those in the company's EGMA service area will receive a 5 percent reduction, while customers who get service through its NSTAR subsidiary will pay 7 percent more.

All customers will also get at least a $20 bill credit in January and February, usually the coldest months of the year. NSTAR customers will get $30 for those months and $25 in March in consolation for an increase an Eversource spokesperson attributed to increased infrastructure costs, deferred from last winter.

"Energy affordability remains a top priority for the DPU," a DPU spokesperson wrote in a statement, "and it will take every possible step to ensure that customers receive the most reliable service at the lowest possible cost."

Prices for the fuel itself, as opposed to delivery fees, are at their lowest in years, thanks to a projected warmer winter and higher production and reserves.

But the good news may be fleeting for customers of National Grid, which serves more than half of ratepayers in the state. The DPU is weighing the company's request to raise its base distribution rates, which could increase bills by up to 11 percent at the start of next year.

At issue is the complex system that utilities use to charge for gas. One portion of the bill — the actual

GAS RATES, Page A10



PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF



A SMASHING DAY TO DRESS UP

Right before Halloween, some brave pumpkins made the sacrifice and allowed themselves to be dropped from the roof of a Boston University building, to the delight of hundreds of students and others at the annual event. In West Roxbury, residents of the German Centre assisted living home cheered as students from the nearby St. Theresa of Avila School showed off their costumes.

'He was very driven, very enthusiastic, very inquisitive.'

BOB CATALINI, *on former student Steve Kornacki*

From middle school blackboards in Groton to the 'big board'



NBC NEWS

Steve Kornacki credits his sixth-grade teacher with spurring his interest in politics, which put him on TV.

By Aidan Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

Days before the midterm elections, political analyst Steve Kornacki briefly pivoted away from preparing to staff the NBC News "big board" maps for a different horse race: a literal one.

Kornacki, the Groton native who achieved star status as America's "chartthrob" during the 2020 election and serves as chief data analyst for NBC News and NBC Sports, decamped this week to Lexington, Ky. to cover the Breeders' Cup. In 2020, he energetically broke down days of vote-tallying in his signature Gap khaki pants, earning him a spot on People's "Sexiest Men of 2020."

Kornacki's full-time move from MSNBC to NBC News since the last national election has expanded his excitable presence and data-driven analysis in elections and in the world of sports. But there's a more personal side to Kornacki's trip to Kentucky. He'll be meeting there with Bob Catalini, a former school teacher

KORNACKI, Page A7

Vt. maverick may find himself riding the wrong wave

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

In a less partisan era, Lieutenant Governor John Rodgers might be just the kind of character who would waltz to reelection in Vermont, a ticket-splitting state that has simultaneously sent a Brooklyn-born democratic socialist to the Senate and a racecar-driving Republican to the governor's office.

Long before it became legal in Vermont, Rodgers was growing marijuana in the Northeast Kingdom town of Glover. Now he does it professionally on a 379-acre farm his family has owned for nearly two centuries.

A bareknuckle brawler with a reputation for letting it fly — the "Yosemite Sam" of Glover, as his campaign chairman calls him — Rodgers has the quirky portfolio (pro-gun, pro-gay rights, anti-wind power) and homespun character that rural states such as Vermont used to specialize in: A "hipneck," as Erica Heilman, a radio producer for Vermont Public, calls him —

RODGERS, Page A6

Prisoner Christa Pike said she's in constant pain and has been kept largely in isolation in her first comments since her botched execution. **A2.**

Binance, the world's largest cryptocurrency exchange, said it lost $6 billion in an attack by hackers. **A3.**



Daylight saving time ends at 2 a.m. Sunday. Turn your clocks back an hour.

Giving me chills

Saturday: Sunny but cooler. High 52-57. Low 37-42.

Sunday: Very nice.

Weather and Comics, D4-5.

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